

Species: Purple Finch
(Vernacular name)Carpodacus purpureus
(Scientific name)

If you watch birds solely for your own enjoyment, a written description of your observations is unnecessary. But, if you have seen something unusual, and would like to share this with others, a written description is essential. Compilers of regional bird lists must insist that their records be scientifically sound; future bird students--those studying occurrences 50 years from now--must have a written record on which to depend. By providing the verifying written description, you are employing a basic rule of the scientific method.

We recognize that experienced field observers can provide important and reliable records, if supported by an adequate verifying description. Thus this request is an effort to perpetuate your record by obtaining concrete evidence which may be permanently preserved for examination by others in the future. This procedure is required for every extraordinary observation, irrespective of the observer.

Date (s): January 3, 1981 Time Bird Seen: 9:00 a.m. to 9:15 a.m.Locality: Bonny Reservoir, Yuma County Colo. Lat/long 14

Nearest town, county and state:

Optical equipment: 7x35 binoculars

If photographed, please enclose copy. Equipment used:

Number of birds seen: 4 Sex: 1 male 3 female Plumage: good.Light conditions: GoodDistance from bird, and how measured: 15-30 feet estimated. First observed at eye level, at 15 feet, then observed from underneath while perched in a small cottonwood tree.

Describe the bird's overall behavior:

Feeding together as a species group, although moving in association with a flock of other passerines, mainly Tree Sparrows.

* We viewed them first at about eye level as they fed in the dried plant stalks, where we had very good views of the male, first, noting the rosy back, and of the female, noting the bold face markings. Then we looked up at them about 15 feet up, noting the clear undertail coverts and the deeply notched tails.

Describe the habitat in which you observed the bird:

Feeding in a patch of standing, dried vegetation of various species, about 3-5 feet high, at the edge of a strip of cottonwoods which borders Bonny Reservoir. They then moved into a small cottonwood, about 15 feet high, and perched there for several minutes. *

*Worling says its was a Russian Olive.

Other observers who independently identified this bird (Please list name and address):

marks used to identify the bird, but include a complete description of the bird. Include size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern; details on shape or size of bill, wings, and tail. (Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions is not enough.) Describe what you actually saw in the field.

Both male and females: finch-like bill; deeply notched tails (see drawing). Chunkier shape than House Finch, and seemingly slightly larger. (than a House Finch).

Male: Rasy Head, bright rose on crown and back of neck; rose slightly lighter down nape and over back, which had stripes underlying the rose color. The overall color of the back and head was about the same, except that the back seemed darker because of the striping.

The undertail coverts were plain and unstriped, although the bird had one or two very faint stripes on the side of the lower belly. Tail deeply forked.

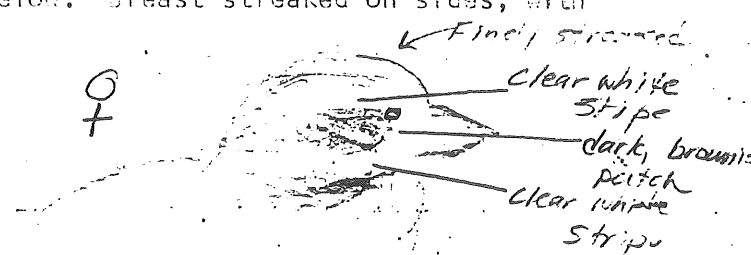
Females: Striped dark brown and white. Finely streaked crown; bold brownish patch on cheek outlined by broad white stripes above and below. Breast streaked on sides, with a clear area in the middle (see drawing).

On one female, the stripes were blended together to form brownish blobs instead of streaks; another had quite crisp breast stripes.

Their undertail coverts were plain and unstriped, and the breast area was distinctly and noticeably clear white.

Describe the bird's calls or sounds, if heard; including method of delivery-- i.e., from perch, in flight, etc.:

No sounds.

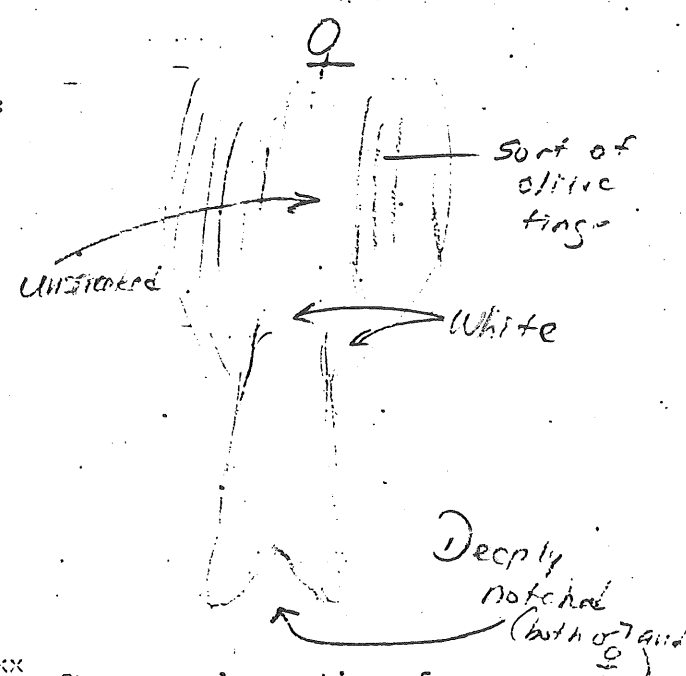


List similar species and how you eliminated them:

House Finch: These birds were chunkier than the House Finch, did not have breast streaking; the females' breast streakings were much heavier.

Cassin's Finch: Male: lack of contrast between crown and neck or back; deeply notched tail.

Females: bold markings on face and clear undertail coverts, and deeply notched tail separated our birds from Cassin's.



Prior experience with this and similar species:

Extensive observations of House & Cassin's. Limited experience with Purple. This is the first time we have been satisfied with a Colorado Id. of a Purple Finch.

This report was written from notes made during xx after observation; from memory .

NAME (print): Ulline & Hugh Kingery

Mailing address: 869 Milwaukee Street, Denver 80206

Signature: _____

Return to:

Hugh E. Kingery
869 Milwaukee Street
Denver, Colorado 80206